crossed into Soviet air space over the Chukchi Peninsula in eastern Siberia. Maultsby recounts how he fought off a panic attack as he realised his predicament, but with the aid of US navigators eventually turned his plane around and headed for Alaska (ignoring siren Soviet radio operators telling him to head deeper into Soviet air space). By then, he was running short of fuel, and had shut off the engine. As he glided down from 75,000 to 25,000ft, he became vulnerable to Soviet interceptors.

It was great testimony to his flying skills that Maultsby got his U-2 back safely, after a ten-and-a-half-hour flight. Shortly afterwards, he was flown to SAC headquarters to meet the commander-in-chief of SAC. General Power displayed no irritation at his pilot. He only expressed regret that the aircraft was not equipped with electronic intelligence-gathering devices to measure the workings of Soviet air defences. Whereas the concern of civilian officials was that the incident might provoke a nuclear war, General Power's interest lay in his bomber penetration routes.

Maultsby was unaware that Soviet air defence fighters had been scrambled to intercept him. He was aware of the two F-102 Corsair Delta Daggers scrambled from Galena Air Force Base in western Alaska to escort him home. In 1994 Scott Sagan revealed that, under the prevailing DEFCON 3 alert state, the US fighters carried Falcon GAR-11 air-to-air missiles, each armed with a small nuclear warhead (with a yield of a quarter of a kiloton).[57] There were no electronic locking devices on the Falcons. Had the US and Soviet aircraft joined in combat, the decision whether to cross the nuclear threshold would have rested on the discipline and judgement of the individual US pilots. Sagan outlines various scenarios that could have led to their firing, including where regional air defence commanders acted within their authority but on mistaken assumptions or perceptions. What is striking about the episode is that civilian leaders in Washington were unaware that the USAF had sent aircraft armed with nuclear weapons into a potential combat zone.

War with the Soviet Union